"Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication."
- Leonardo da Vinci

ACADEMIC WRITING

Effective paraphrasing and summarizing

Developed and compiled by
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DISCUSSION

1. Paraphrase definition: "*a statement that expresses something that someone has said or written using different words…*" (Oxford Learner's Dictionary of Academic English (c) Oxford University Press 2014)

THE IMPORTANCE OF EFFECTIVE PARAPHRASING: MATCHING EXERCISE

Instructions: Match each title (1–6) with the correct description (A–F). Write the correct letter next to each number.

Titles

1. …… Avoids plagiarism
2. …… Demonstrates comprehension of source material
3. …… Develops academic literacy skills
4. …… Supports coherence and academic voice
5. …… Facilitates argument development
6. …… Minimizes overreliance on quotations

Descriptions

A. Paraphrasing allows students to blend evidence into their writing in a way that supports their position. It enables them to shape information around their views while still respecting the original source's intent.

B. This benefit shows that a student truly understands what they have read. Rewriting in one's own words reflects critical engagement, rather than simply repeating ideas.

C. By paraphrasing instead of overusing direct quotes, students keep the focus on their own ideas. This approach also helps them use external sources more selectively and effectively.

D. Through regular paraphrasing, learners enhance their vocabulary, grammar, and writing style—all key components of academic success.

E. When done correctly and cited properly, paraphrasing helps students stay within ethical academic guidelines. It reduces the risk of copying or presenting someone else's work as their own.

F. Paraphrased content tends to flow more naturally within a student's own writing. It helps maintain a consistent academic tone and makes the text easier to follow.

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PARAPHRASE TECHNIQUES

Original passage

Much of the technology of the movie industry was invented in Europe during the nineteenth century, with England and France providing an initial impetus to commercial development from 1895. However, the tumult of the First World War stunted the growth of a European film industry, and dominance soon passed to America, which oversaw from 1915 the emergence of the feature film and the grand studio in Hollywood, California.

Paraphrase

European countries created many of the technologies for the film industry in the 19th century. From 1895, its development was initially driven commercially by France and England. However, the turmoil of WW1 hampered the growth of the movie industry in Europe, so that America came to dominate from 1915. At this time, large studios and feature films emerged from Hollywood, California

(Original passage adapted from: Crystal, D. (2012) 'A global language'. In: Seargeant, P. and Swann, J., (eds.) English in the World: History, Diversity and Change. Milton Keynes: The Open University, pp. 250-319.)

Paraphrase Technique Questions

1. Compare the original passage and the paraphrase sentence by sentence. **Analyze how the sentence structure and words differ by answering the following questions:**

a) What is the 4th word of the first sentence in the original passage? Where does this word appear in first sentence of the paraphrase?

.....

b) Which word paraphrases *dominance* in line 3 of the original extract?

.....

c) Which words replace *invented* in line 1 and *stunted* in line 3 of the original passage?

.....

d) Which sentence in the original becomes two sentences in the paraphrase. …….....

2. *Paraphrase techniques* (corresponding to answers above)*:*

a) ……..……...

b) …….

c) ……..……...

d) …….

USING SYNONYMS AND CHANGING WORD FORMS

1. Find the corresponding synonym or change in word form in the paraphrase for each of the words in blue italics in the original passage:

EXTRACT

It has been **a)** *posited* that Rapid Eye Movement (REM) sleep might **b)** *have a role* in memory consolidation. Karlsen (2022) found that rats often **c)** *performed* much worse on learning tasks after being **d)** *selectively* **e)** *deprived* of REM sleep. This indicates that REM sleep is necessary in order to consolidate the memory of how to **f)** *complete* a task.

PARAPHRASE

Example: a) posited → s*uggested* = *synonym*

b) have a role → ……..…… =……..…….

c) perform → ……..…… = ……..…….

d) selectively → ……..…… = ……..…….

e) deprived → ……..…… = ……..…….

f) complete → ……..…… = ……..…….

PARAPHRASE

It has been suggested that Rapid Eye Movement (REM) sleep may contribute to memory consolidation. Selective deprivation of REM sleep has been shown to impair rats' performance on learning tasks (Karlsen, 2022). It would therefore seem that the consolidation of a memory of how to accomplish a task requires REM sleep

2. Give a synonym or change the word form of each word in blue italics in the original passage below. **Be careful to choose a synonym that is appropriate in the context:**

EXTRACT

It could also be argued, however, that the observed differences in learning are **a)** simply due to insufficient rest rather than **b)** a lack of REM sleep. Findings which counter the **c)** argument that REM sleep is **d)** required for memory consolidation include the **e)** demonstration that people with brain damage that **f)** suppresses REM sleep have normal memory. Moreover, it has been shown that REM **g)** deprivation after a period of alert learning does not interfere with the **h)** retention of new information.

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PARAPHRASE

On the other hand, it might be the case that the learning differences detected are **i - a)** …….. (*use a synonym*) the result of inadequate rest rather than an **ii - b)** …….. (*use a synonym*) of REM sleep. The fact that brain-damaged individuals with **iii - f)** …….. (*change the word form*) REM sleep have unimpaired memory appears to refute the **iv - c)** …….. (*use a synonym*) that REM sleep is **v - d)** …….. (*use a synonym)* for memory consolidation. Moreover, it has been **vi - e)** (*synonym*) …….. that individuals who are **vii - g**) …….. (*change the word form)* of REM sleep following focused learning are not prevented from **viii - h)** …….. (*change the word form*) new information.

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CHANGING WORD ORDER: An easy way to change the word order is to switch the subject and object:

An uninterrupted sleep	*is necessary*	*for memory consolidation*
SUBJECT	VERB	OBJECT
Memory consolidation	*requires*	*a period of continuous sleep*

1. Change the *word order* of the sentences below. You should also follow the instructions in parentheses:

Example:
Nutrition (find a synonym) appears to affect (change the verb form) length (use: sleep duration) of sleep.

- *Sleep duration seems to be affected by diet*

a) Insufficient (find a synonym) sleep is characterized (change to a noun) by less than six hours' sleep for most people (use: *for the general population*).

For the general population .....

.....

b) Sleep deprivation (find a synonym) usually (find a synonym) *impairs* (change the verb form) memory processes (find a synonym).

Memory .....

.....

c) Overall (find a synonym), REM sleep occupies (change the verb form) about (find a synonym) 20% of the sleep cycle (use: sleep period).

.....

.....

d) The findings showed (find a synonym) that disrupted (find a synonym) sleep is associated with (find a synonym) adverse (find a synonym) health outcomes (find a synonym)

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RETAINING MEANING

1. When paraphrasing, it is important to keep the meaning of the original text, without adding or removing information, and without copying words unnecessarily. **Read the extract text below and then decide which is the better paraphrase, (a) or (b):**

EXTRACT

Deep learning is characterized by perseverance and curiosity for a topic. Students adopting this approach have an inner motivation to understand what is taught. They often interact with arguments and evaluate whether they are justified by the evidence. Moreover, they are able to reshape their ideas based on new learning. (Written by Andrew Pearson in 2020)

PARAPHRASE A

Pearson (2020) proposes that persistence and inquisitiveness are typical features of deep learning. Students who learn in this way are intrinsically motivated to understand the ideas presented and tend to engage with arguments while assessing if they are adequately supported. In addition, such students are capable of reformulating their ideas to accommodate new knowledge.

PARAPHRASE B

According to Pearson (2020), the characteristics of deep learning include commitment and curiosity for a topic. By adopting this approach, students are internally motivated to grasp the meaning of new information; they consider carefully all the evidence and offer valid arguments. Additionally, they are able to modify their ideas based on new learning.

Note why A or B is not as effective:

……

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HOW TO WRITE AN EFFECTIVE PARAPHRASE

- Read the original passage several times until you understand it well
- You may find it helpful to underline the main points
- Make notes in the space provided, changing vocabulary words wherever possible
- Write your paraphrase in your own words. Remember to use synonyms and change word forms, and sentence/word order. You can also split and join sentences
- Check your paraphrase to make sure you have not changed the meaning of the original passage.
- Add a citation

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PRACTISE PARAPHRASING I

1. Find synonyms in the passage below for the following words:

1. Nonetheless (adverb): ….....……..…….....
2. Study (noun): …….…….....…….…….…….....
3. Even though ……
4. Unspoiled (adjective): …….…….…….....…….....
5. Usual (adjective): ……..…….……..…....…….....
6. Decomposition (noun): ……..……..…….……...…….....
7. Base (noun): ……...……....…….……....…….....
8. Consequently (adverb) : .....……....……..……....….....….

2. Write a paraphrase of the passage below (written by Alan Barham in 2018):

POLLUTION IN ANTARCTICA

Before the last century no humans had visited Antarctica, and even today it has a population in winter of less than 200 people. However, recent research has indicated high levels of pollution within the snow. Although Antarctica is in pristine condition compared with other regions in the world, the normal process of decay on this continent is prevented because of the bitter cold. As a result, some research stations are surrounded by accumulations of rubbish dating back 60 years.

PARAPHRASE

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Adapted from: Bailey, B. (2011) *Academic writing: a handbook for international students*. 3rd ed. Abingdon: Routledge.

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PEER REVIEW OF PARAPHRASE

Give your paraphrase to another student who will complete the peer review below:

The student has:

used synonyms	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
changed word forms	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
changed word order within sentences where appropriate	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
changed sentence order; split or joined sentences where appropriate	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
Given an appropriate citation	**Yes**		**No**

COMMENT

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The paraphrase is accurate	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
The paraphrase has omitted information	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
The paraphrase has added information	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
The paraphrase is too similar to the original	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**

COMMENT

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PEER REVIEW OF PARAPHRASE

GRAMMAR/LEXIS

1. Try to find some grammatical/lexical errors in your partner's paraphrase. You should indicate which type of error has been made in the paragraph using comments (and track changes if needed). You may wish to use the symbols or abbreviations in the table below:

2. Note how many errors occur in the table below:

TYPE OF ERROR	Number	TYPE OF ERROR	Number
ww = wrong word		prep = wrong preposition	
number = word should be singular or plural?		art = article should be changed or deleted	
tense = wrong tense		vf = wrong form of verb	
punct. = wrong punctuation		wf = wrong form of word	
informal = informal word used		^ = word missing	
/ = unnecessary word		sp = wrong spelling	
wo = wrong word order		**?** = meaning unclear	
cs = comma splice run-on = run-on sentence		coll = these words do not collocate	
sf = sentence fragment		**?** = meaning unclear	

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SUMMARISING IN AN ACADEMIC CONTEXT

PROCEDURE

1. **Put the following sentences into a suitable order:**

a) = …….. Ideas that are not relevant to your essay title should be disregarded; examples, definitions and dates may also be omitted, unless these are viewed as essential for the purposes of the essay.

b) = 2 It is important to consider why the author has written this text, and which of the ideas presented are useful for your essay.

c) = ……. It is worthwhile reviewing the summary to ensure the meaning of the source text has been retained and is appropriate in the context of your essay.

d) = ……. Relevant key points should be highlighted or underlined, from which notes may be taken using a variety of paraphrase techniques such as synonyms or different word forms;

e) = ……. The original passage should be read carefully, and important vocabulary checked in a monolingual dictionary.

f) = …….. The summary should be written within the essay, based on the aforementioned notes, along with a citation linking a summary to the source.

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PRACTICE SUMMARY WRITING 1

Underline the main points in the extract below, written by Alan Barham in 2018. **Then write a summary in two sentences:**

Halley research center, Antarctica

POLLUTION IN ANTARCTICA

Before the last century no humans had visited Antarctica, and even today it has a population in winter of less than 200 people. However, recent research has indicated high levels of pollution within the snow. Although Antarctica is in pristine condition compared with other regions in the world, the normal process of decay on this continent is prevented because of the bitter cold. As a result, some research stations are surrounded by accumulations of rubbish dating back 60 years.

SUMMARY:

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ANALYSIS OF TEXT & SUMMARIES

1. The following extract reports an experiment. Imagine that you wish to report the *method* (i.e., what the baboons had done)**,** *results and conclusion* in an essay. Read the following text and underline the key points. You should then compare your underlined points with those of your partner and try to reach an agreement.

Extract from an article written by Li Fang in 2019:

It is clear from the current research that baboons are able to think abstractly. It has been known for some time that chimpanzees are capable of abstract thought, but baboons are a more distant relation to mankind. In the experiment, two baboons were trained to use a personal computer and a joystick. The animals had to match patterns on the computer screen which very similar but had superficial differences. Surprisingly, the baboons' success rate was above 50%.

Adapted from: Bailey, B. (2011) *Academic writing: a handbook for international students*. 3rd ed. Abingdon: Routledge.

2. Compare the following summaries, **and decide which one is best, giving reasons:**

a) According to Li (2019), baboons have the ability to think in an abstract way. The animals in her study were taught to use a computer and then had to select designs that were similar, which they did at a rate better than by chance.

b) Baboons are a kind of monkey more distant from man than chimpanzees. Although it is known that chimpanzees are able to think abstractly, until recently it was not clear if baboons could do the same. However, new research by various scientists has shown that this is so (Li, 2019).

c) According to a recent study (Li, 2019), baboons are able to think in an abstract way. Researchers trained two baboons to use a personal computer and a joystick, and they found that the animals did better than would be expected.

Reasons: ……..

…….

…….

…….

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PRACTICE SUMMARY WRITING 2

1. Read the following text (written by Paul Santon in 2021) and underline the key points:

WEALTH AND FERTILITY

For most of the past century an inverse correlation between human fertility and economic development has been found. This means that as a country became richer, the average number of children born to each woman became smaller. According to Bones (2018), while in the poorest countries women often have eight children, the rate fell as low as 1.3 in some European countries such as Italy, which is below the replacement rate. Such a low rate has two likely negative consequences: the population will fall in the long term, and a growing number of old people will have to be supported by a shrinking number of young. However, a recent study (Kirk and Martin, 2020) suggests that this pattern may be changing. They related countries' fertility rates to their human development index (HDI), a figure with a maximum value of 1.0, which assesses life expectancy, average income and education level. Over 20 countries now have an HDI of more than 0.9, and in a majority of these the fertility rate has started to increase; in some countries, it is approaching two children per woman. Although there are exceptions such as Japan, it appears that higher levels of wealth and education eventually translate into a desire for more children.

2. Write notes (*do not write full sentences*) of the key points below:

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3. Join the notes together and use them to make a summary of approximately 50-70 words. Give citations where appropriate:

SUMMARY I:

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4. You have been asked to write an essay entitled: *Discuss current trends in fertility in countries with high levels of income and education.*

Write an appropriate summary (about 20-35 words) to be used in YOUR ESSAY using information from your notes or the above summary. Be careful to cite correctly, using secondary referencing if appropriate:

SUMMARY II: Summary of information for an essay

……

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PEER REVIEW OF SUMMARIES

Give your summaries to another student who will complete the peer review below:

SUMMARIES I AND II

The student has:

used synonyms	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
changed word forms	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
changed word order	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**

COMMENT

……

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SUMMARY I

The summary accurately conveys the main ideas	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
Important ideas have been included	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
Unimportant ideas have been omitted	**Yes**	**Sometimes**	**No**
Citations have been given, and are formatted correctly	**Yes**		**No**

SUMMARY II

The summary is useful and relevant to the essay title	**Yes**	**No**
A citation has been given, and is formatted correctly	**Yes**	**No**

COMMENT

……..

……

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PEER REVIEW OF SUMMARY

GRAMMAR

a) Try to find some grammatical errors in your partner's paragraph. You should use track changes where possible and also indicate errors using comments.

b) Note how many errors occur in the table below:

Type of error	Number of errors	Type of error	Number of errors
ww = wrong word		prep = wrong preposition	
number = word should be singular or plural?		art = article should be changed or deleted	
tense = wrong tense		vf = wrong form of verb	
p = wrong punctuation		wf = wrong form of word	
informal = informal word used		^ = word missing	
/ = unnecessary word		sp = wrong spelling	
wo = wrong word order		**?** meaning unclear	
cs = comma splice (run-on sentence)			

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RECORDING NEW VOCABULARY

Use may use this page to record important new vocabulary

WORD	PRONUNCIATION	WORD FORM	
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			
Example sentence(s)			

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